

DEADPOOL & WOLVERINE: THE NOVELIZATION

CHAPTER ONE: The Anchor and the Earth

The wind in North Dakota doesn't just blow; it hunts.

It finds the gaps in your suit, the microscopic seams in your bespoke red spandex that you paid a cosplayer in Burbank way too much to double-stitch, and it works its way in like a lover with cold hands. It was the kind of cold that settled deep in the marrow, the kind that reminded you that the world was old, indifference, and entirely sick of your shit. It was a cold that didn't care about your franchise rights or your box office projections. It just wanted to turn your blood into slush.

I stood there, boots crunching on the permafrost—a sound like stepping on a box of breakfast cereal wrapped in a wet towel—looking at the crude wooden cross. It was tilted, forty-five degrees. An X.

Cute. Branding is important, even in death. Especially in death. You want the tourists to know where to leave the flowers and the Funko Pops.

Somewhere in the distance, The Platters were singing "Only You." It wasn't coming from anywhere specific. It was just **there**, vibrating in the air molecules, an earworm manifested by the sheer narrative weight of the moment. Or maybe I'd left a Bluetooth speaker on a rock somewhere. It's hard to keep track of inventory when you're having a mental breakdown.

You know, I thought, the internal monologue running on the dual-tracks of a manic narrator and a cynical game dev crunching for a patch release, **for a long time I wasn't sure I'd ever be back. The Corporate Overlords—praise be to the Mouse, hallowed be His ears—bought the Fox house. It was a hostile takeover of the server. There was a whole boring rights issue, a bureaucratic dungeon crawl of IP lawyers and non-compete clauses that would make a Kafka protagonist drink bleach.**

We were in Purgatory. Not the biblical one, which probably has better catering, but the Hollywood one. The Grey Zone. The Void where franchises go to wait for a reboot or a streaming series that nobody asked for. It was a waiting room with old magazines and a flickering fluorescent light that hummed in the key of anxiety.

But then it turned out they wanted me.

Me. The Merc with the Mouth. The Regenerating Degenerate. The one guy who shouldn't even have his own movie, much less a franchise. It's like inviting the hobo who screams at pigeons to the Royal Wedding because he once correctly guessed the Queen's weight to the decimal point. It's a glitch in the simulation. A rounding error in the great cosmic spreadsheet.

Marvel's so stupid.

I looked at the grave. A coffee mug sat perched on a rock nearby, frost forming on its ceramic lip. "I LIKE ME." It was an affirmation. It was a lie. It was merchandise. It was \$14.99 plus shipping and handling.

Look, Constant Nerd, I told the air, addressing the fourth wall that was currently thinner than the ozone layer, **we all saw the trailer. We know the title of this thing. I see you typing on your forums. I see your Reddit threads. I know what you're wondering. How are we going to do this without dishonoring Logan's memory? How do we navigate the Sacred Timeline without taking a steaming dump on the grave of the only serious, Oscar-nominated movie this franchise ever made?**

I grabbed the shovel. The handle was cold enough to burn skin, but my skin was a topography of scar tissue and cancer, so I didn't feel much. Just the pressure. The weight of the tool. The promise of labor.

And I'll tell you how...

I drove the spade into the frozen earth. It resisted. The ground was hard as iron, frozen since the Cretaceous period. It sparked. Actual sparks.

...We're not.

Digging a grave is hard work.

In the movies, it's a montage. A few rhythmic scoops, some dramatic lighting, maybe a slow-motion shot of sweat flying off a bicep. The music swells, the camera pans, and suddenly you're six feet deep.

In reality, it's a grind. It's manual labor in a server that has turned the physics engine up to 'Punishing.'

I dug.

The shovel hit dirt. *Thunk.*

It hit a root. *Crack.*

It hit a rock. *Clang.*

My shoulders burned. My healing factor was working overtime, knitting torn muscle fibers back together as fast as I could tear them. It was a cycle of destruction and rebirth, played out in the microcosm of my deltoids. Every scoop was a rep in the gym of existential dread.

The wind bit at my exposed face (mask up for optimal oxygen intake, also to spit). The frost formed on my eyelashes, turning the world into a blurry, crystalline watercolor painting.

You think I want to be out here in Butt-Fuck North Dakota digging up the one and only Wolverine? No thank you. I'd rather be at home, watching the Great British Bake Off and seeing if Paul Hollywood's eyes can actually impregnate a contestant through the screen. I'd rather be playing Hello Kitty Island Adventure. I'd rather be doing literally anything else.

But the fate of my entire world was at stake. My timeline was dying. My friends were dying. My server was shutting down. The admins had sent the notification: *Server Shutdown in 5 Minutes.*

He may not be living his best life, but he sure as hell ain't dead.

Regenerative healing factors don't just stop. They are the glitch in the system. The cheat code that keeps the game running when it should have crashed to desktop. Logan wasn't dead. He was just buffering. He was stuck in a respawn loop. He was lagging.

I dug until my hands blistered inside the gloves. Then I dug until the blisters popped and healed and blistered again. I dug until the sun started to peek over the horizon, a cold, indifferent eye watching a madman desecrate a national monument.

SHUNK.

The sound was different.

It wasn't dirt. It wasn't rock. It was metal on something... else. Something hollow. Something wooden.

"Well, there you are," I said, my breath pluming like dragon smoke in the frigid air. "Yes, yes, yes, yes."

I scrambled down into the hole, a red-suited mole rat in a fever dream. I cleared the dirt with my hands. My gloves were torn, my fingernails packed with frozen mud. I clawed at the earth like a man possessed. Like a fanboy trying to open a mint-condition action figure without damaging the box.

I cleared the last layer. I found the lid of the makeshift coffin.

I pried it open.

And I stopped.

The air in the grave was still. It smelled of decay, yes, but dry decay. Old dust. It smelled like a library that had burned down and then frozen over.

It was... disappointing.

It was bone.

Just bone. Adamantium-laced, sure, shiny and chrome like a car bumper in a showroom, but bone nonetheless. The metal had fused with the calcium, creating a lattice of indestructible failure.

There was no flesh. No muscle. No growl. No scowling Australian refusing to help me. Just a skeleton wearing the tattered remains of a tank top.

"Come on," I whispered. My voice cracked. "Son of a bitch."

I touched the ribcage. It was cold. Final.

I stood up in the grave. The frustration boiled over, hot and acidic.

"AGHH MOTHER-FUCKER-- MY WORLD IS FUCKED!"

I swung the shovel.

It connected with the cross—*CRACK*—sending wood spinning into the grey sky. I smashed it again. The vibration traveled up my arms, rattling my teeth in their sockets. I smashed it until the handle splintered. I broke the shovel across my thigh, the sound of the wood snapping echoing like a gunshot in the silence.

I tossed the pieces into the hole.

The metal tip of the shovel bounced off the adamantium ribcage—*CLANG*—and flew back out, a final middle finger from the universe. A physics glitch. A reminder that even in death, Wolverine was annoying.

I spun around, dizzy, the world tilting on its axis, and fell backward into the hole.

Just me and the skeleton. The Odd Couple. One rotting, one unable to rot. Lying in the dirt, waiting for the credits to roll.

"That was weird," I said to the corpse, staring up at the rectangle of grey sky. "I'm much calmer now. Look, I'm not a man of science, but you seem incredibly passed away."

I sighed. The wind howled above us, a lonely, mournful sound.

"But it's good to see ya."

I climbed out. I sat on the edge of the grave, legs dangling. I pulled the skeleton up next to me. We leaned against the tree. The same tree where he died in *Logan*. The tree that made grown men cry in theaters across the world. The tree that launched a thousand think-pieces about the "Gritty Superhero Movie."

He was sitting there, or what was left of him. The adamantium skeleton was posed casually, legs folded. If he hadn't been a grim collection of metal and rot, it would have looked like two dudes hanging out in the woods, maybe sharing a beer, maybe talking about how the fishing was.

"I've gotta be honest," I said, leaning in. "I've always wanted to ride with you, Log'. You and me, getting into it. Deadpool and Wolverine just fucking shit up. Can you imagine the fun? The chaos? The residuals?"

I switched to the accent. I couldn't help it. It was a defense mechanism. A mask over the mask.

"G'day mate. There's nothing that'll bring me back to life faster than a big bag of Marvel cash."

I dropped the accent. It tasted bitter.

"Me too, Hugh. But no. No, no, no. You had to get all noble and die for real. Goddamnit, I could really use your help right now—"

The air shimmered.

It wasn't the heat. It was a tear in the fabric of reality. A digital glitch in the high-res texture of the woods.

A glowing orange rectangle appeared. The kind that screamed *Load Zone*.

A Time Door.

They spilled out like ants from a kicked hill. The Minutemen. The TVA. The fun police of the multiverse. The moderators of the server.

They looked upgraded since their last patch notes. Better armor—matte black, tactical, useless against main characters. Bigger sticks—glowing with the prune energy that erased you from existence.

I popped my head out of the grave like a gopher in a red condom.

"WAIT! I'm warning you! I'm not alone."

"Wade Winston Wilson!" one of them shouted. His voice was amplified, distorted. "You are under arrest by the Time Variance Authority for too many crimes to list. Come out and we'll give you the courtesy of taking you in one piece."

"Ughhhh," I groaned, sliding back down into the dirt. "Death by day-player."

"Last chance: Throw out your weapons and come out peacefully."

The voice came from everywhere and nowhere, amplified by the kind of high-end PA system that tax dollars shouldn't be buying for time cops.

I looked at the skeleton. I looked at the adamantium ribs, shining like silverware in a drawer that hadn't been opened since the 1990s. The strongest metal in the universe, woven into the calcium of a man who spent his life hurting.

"I'm not gonna give you my weapons," I called out, my voice bouncing off the frozen hills.

I grabbed Logan's hand. It was cold. Not just winter cold. Dead cold. The kind of cold that absorbs heat from everything it touches.

"But I promise not to use *them*."

I turned to the camera—the invisible lens that I knew was there, the eye of the Constant Nerd, the voyeur in the darkened theater of my mind.

"There are 206 bones in the human body," I whispered, feeling the geometry of the skeleton. "207 if I'm watching Gossip Girl."

I high-fived the skeletal hand. The sound was a dry *clack*, like billiard balls colliding.

"Here we go. **Maximum Effort**."

The music started. Not in the world, but in the soundtrack of the universe. *NSync.* "Bye, Bye, Bye." A song so catchy it was classified as a biological weapon by the Geneva Convention.

I moved.

It wasn't a jump; it was an eruption. I flew out from behind the dirt pile, holding Logan's skeleton by the neck like a macabre dance partner. The vertebrae rattled.

"Okay, Peanut. Guess we're getting that team up after all."

I landed in the snow. The Minutemen hesitated. Just for a frame. It was the hesitation of men who were expecting a surrender and got a corpse-wielding maniac instead.

That hesitation was all I needed.

I grabbed an adamantium rib. I pulled.

Snap.

The sound was wet and sharp, like stepping on a dry branch wrapped in wet leather. The connective tissue—rotted, frozen, but still there—gave way. I held the curved bone in my hand. It was perfectly balanced. A scimitar made of a superhero.

I threw it.

The bone didn't fly; it deleted space. It spun through the air, catching the pale winter light. As it flew, I saw the text. Giant, floating, 3D letters manifesting in the air like a localized hallucination. **THE MARVEL CINEMATIC UNIVERSE PRESENTS.**

The rib hit the lead Minuteman in the chest.

THWACK-CRUNCH.

The sound of metal punching through futuristic polymer armor and the sternum beneath was sickeningly distinct. It was the sound of a heavy book being slammed onto a counter of raw meat. The Minuteman went down, gasping, pink froth bubbling at the intake of his helmet.

I moved into the dance. I wasn't fighting; I was editing.

I snapped off the clavicles. Dual-wielding collarbones.

A Minuteman lunged with a Time Stick. The orange energy crackled, promising erasure. I parried with a thigh bone—still attached to the shin by rotting tendons, a flail of indestructible death.

I swung it like Bruce Lee on bath salts.

WHACK.

The heavy end of the femur connected with a helmet. The faceplate shattered. The head inside did something worse. It didn't just break; it caved. It was a soft melon meeting a sledgehammer. The Minuteman dropped without a sound, just a sack of meat suddenly devoid of the electrical impulse to stand.

A FILM BY SHAWN LEVY. The letters appeared in the spray of blood.

"Mullin! I'm outside the box!" I screamed, ripping another rib loose.

I stabbed. The jagged end of the rib slid into a throat. There was resistance—skin, cartilage, muscle—and then a hot spray of arterial red that painted the snow in an abstract expressionist nightmare. It was warm. Sticky. Real.

This wasn't CGI. This was wet work. This was the Blackmore texture pack.

I grabbed the pelvis. A shield. A weapon. I slammed it into a Minuteman, driving him back. He stumbled, his own Time Stick brushing his leg.

ZZRRRPT.

He pruned himself. Gone. Erased from the server. A cloud of purple smoke where a man used to be.

"Come on, big fella."

I grabbed the forearms.

I widened the radius and ulna, sliding my own gloved arms inside the thoracic cage of the forearm bones. They fit. Like they were made for me. Like a hug from a ghost.

I stood there, breathing heavy, the cold air burning my lungs. The Minutemen regrouped, uncertain. They were looking at a madman wearing a dead superhero like a suit of armor.

I flexed my wrists.

SHNIKT.

The claws popped.

The sound was pure. It was the sound of consequences. It was the sound of a promise kept.

I stood hunched, backlit by the winter sun, the adamantium blades extending from my fists, dripping with snow and potential violence.

"I am soaking wet right now," I growled.

And then I roared. A primal sound, half-animal, half-glitch, echoing across the frozen wastes of North Dakota, promising pain, promising chaos, promising a sequel.

CHAPTER TWO: The Interview

Freeze Frame.

Record Scratch.

Voiceover Mode: Engaged.

To be clear, I'm not proud of any of this. The wanton violence. The whiff of necrophilia. It isn't who I am. It isn't who I want to be.

Who I want to be... well, that's a different story. A simpler story. A story before the rot set in. To help you understand that, I've gotta take you back. Back before the timeline turned into a dumpster fire.

Flashback noise. *Wavy lines.* *Harp music.*

March, 2018. Earth-616.

The commute had been a nightmare.

New York in 616 is different. It's cleaner, shiny, more... expensive. The Avengers Tower loomed over the city like a monument to capitalism and hubris. It was a giant 'A' stamping its approval on the skyline.

I adjusted my hoodie. It was my nice hoodie. The one without the bloodstains. I had even ironed it, which mostly just involved hitting it with a hot pan on the counter of my apartment.

I walked into the lobby. It smelled of money. Not the dirty, crumpled singles of a mercenary's duffel bag, but the clean, digital scent of assets that appreciate while you sleep. The kind of money that builds towers with names on them.

I sat in the chair, vibrating. My leg was doing a drum solo on the carpet. *Tap-tap-tap.*

Across the desk sat a man who looked like he'd been manufactured in a factory that specialized in "Middle Management: Friendly Edition." Harold Lloyd. Or at least, that's what the nameplate said. To me, he looked like Happy Hogan, the guy who carried Tony Stark's bags.

"Thank you, sir," I said, my voice tight. "For seeing me. I firmly believe that my services could be of great use to your organization."

I tried to look professional. I tried to look like a man who didn't solve problems with katanas and high explosives. I looked around the room. It was a shrine to Tony Stark. Iron Man masks, awards, tech that probably cost more than the GDP of a small country.

"Now, I know I was caught 'Smashturbating' in the lobby of Stark Towers," I continued, rushing the words, tripping over my own desperation. "But I can assure you--"

Harold blinked. "Smashturb-- I'm sorry. What was that?"

"Oh. No, I'm sorry." I waved a hand. "That's when you get those toy Hulk Hands, right, and then you just look down, and you just-- you brace yourself, and you ravage the midsection--"

"I get it, okay," Harold interrupted, his face tightening. "Thank you. The picture's painted."

"You get the gist."

I shifted in the chair. The leather squeaked. It was the sound of a balloon animal being strangled.

This is going poorly, the cynical voice in my head—the Jun Prince filter—observed. *You are an NPC trying to glitch your way into the Main Quest. You are a Level 1 Crook trying to talk to the Guild Master.*

"What exactly brings you here today?" Harold asked.

I took a breath. This was it. The moment. The pitch.

"Why am I--? Wow... Okay." I leaned forward. "I care... I know I turn everything into a joke, but I care, and I want to use that feeling for something important. I want to matter. And to show my girl that I matter."

I looked over my shoulder. The door was closed.

"I feel like I'm wasting the good stuff here... is the Man not gonna be joining us?"

Harold frowned. "The Man?"

"Yeah. I should save this if he's gonna--"

"As far as you're concerned right now, I'm the Man..."

"No."

"The Man is me. I am the Man in this circumstance. He doesn't do this kind of thing anymore."

"Cameos?"

"Meetings. Entry level meetings."

The words hung in the air like a fart in an elevator. *Entry level.*

"Entry level?" I squinted at him. "Aren't you the Chauffeur, maybe...?"

"A common misconception. I did begin my career as Mr. Keaton's driver."

"Chauffeur."

"But quickly pivoted to the head of security."

"The head of-- yes, yes, yes."

Harold sighed. He opened a file. *My* file. It was thin. Painfully thin. It was a pamphlet of failure.

"You seem to have left out whether or not you had any experience as a member of a team," Harold said, his pen hovering over my resume like a drone waiting to strike. "Could you maybe add a little bit of perspective there?"

"Oh no, yes. Of course." I nodded enthusiastically, a bobblehead of desperation. "I was Special Forces, but mainly I was team leader -- founder, really -- of X-Force. Sadly, they all perished in action."

Harold wrote something down. *Scratch. Scratch.*

"How exactly did that happen?"

"Well, the police say 'gravity'," I said, leaning in as if sharing a trade secret. "But just between us, they didn't test well in the focus group, mainly because of Cable. The demographic skew was all wrong. Too much pouch, not enough synergy."

Harold made another note. A bad note. The kind of note that gets your resume put in the "Do Not Call" pile, right next to the guys who write their cover letters in crayon or attach a headshot where they're holding a katana.

"Whoa, oh oh!" I held up a hand. "I can see this isn't going well. Please stop writing. I just... Look..."

My eyes felt hot. Desperation. It's a bitter taste, like licking a 9-volt battery that's been marinated in disappointment.

"I wanna be an Avenger."

Harold stopped writing. He looked at me. Really looked at me. He saw the scars under the hoodie. He saw the frantic energy of a man who knows his franchise is on the bubble.

"I want to be an Avenger."

"Why do you want to be an Avenger?"

"Because look around you," I said, gesturing to the room, to the legacy on the walls. The Iron Man helmets staring back with hollow, judgmental eyes. "They're the best of the best. And what they do matters. I need to be an Avenger. Sir, my girl has kind of had it with my shtick. And if I don't turn things around and do something with my gifts, I don't think it's really going to work out for me, and I wouldn't blame her."

It was the truth. The raw, bleeding truth. And in a room full of corporate superhero branding, truth felt like a foreign contaminant.

Harold leaned back. The leather chair groaned under the weight of his authority.

"Avengers are a very unique group of superheroes that stand for something more than just fighting and wearing costumes," he said, reciting the company mission statement. "I mean, people look up to us. Kids look up to us."

"I'm sorry, *us*?" I blinked. The filter slipped. "I wasn't aware that you were an Avenger..."

"Avengers-adjacent, technically--"

"Oh wow, what's your superpower? Is it parallel parking?" The words were out before I could stop them. My mouth, the traitor. The defense mechanism that fires shrapnel when I'm scared. "I'm so sorry. That was cruel. I lash out when I'm nervous. It won't happen again."

Harold stood up.

"Let's cut to the chase."

"Please."

"You just said, moments ago, that you wanted to be an Avenger because you need it."

"Yessir, I do."

"But the Avengers don't do the job because they need it. They do the job because people need *them*. Do you see the distinction?"

I felt small. Smaller than an atom. Smaller than the chances of this working out. It was the crushing weight of realization: I was playing a different game. I was playing *Grand Theft Auto*; he was playing *SimCity*.

"Yessir. Please, Mr. Lloyd. I don't want to spend the rest of my life like an annoying one trick pony."

"Alright."

He walked me to the door. He put a hand on my shoulder. It was meant to be comforting. It felt like a dismissal. It felt like being escorted out of a mall by security.

"The problem might be that you're reaching a little too high," he said. "Aim for the middle and you'll never miss, right? I think you've got a good heart. I believe what you're saying. But not everybody's the world-saving type. I'm not. But I'm happy, right? I found my place. Find your place."

I stood in the doorway. The hallway stretched out behind me, long and empty. It was the longest hallway I had ever seen.

"Alright, get back out there. We'll keep an eye on you. Good luck."

I hugged him. I hugged him hard. It was awkward. It lingered. It was a hug that said, *Please validate my existence.*

"Alright, fetch the car. I want to hit Shake Shack on the way home."

"Really? Really? -- No, no, please."

I pulled away.

"Okay, thank you."

I walked away. The door closed.

SHUNK. SHUNK. SHUNK.

The sound echoed in the darkness.

You know what they say, the narrator whispered, the voice tired and old. *When one door closes, your locker at work opens.*

CHAPTER THREE: The Salesman

****Earth-10005. Now.****

The locker room smelled of Old Spice, damp towels, and the specific, metallic scent of resignation. It was the smell of men who had given up on their dreams and settled for a dental plan.

****SHUNK.****

I pressed the staple gun against my scalp.

The pain was sharp, immediate, and grounding. It was a reminder that I was still here, still flesh and blood, even if the spirit had left the building years ago. The staple pierced the scar tissue, biting into the periosteum of the skull. It was a small penance. A daily crucifixion.

****SHUNK.****

I was attaching a hair system. A toupee. A chestnut-colored lie that sat on my scarred head like a dead squirrel.

This is the build now, I told myself, looking into the mirror. The face staring back wasn't Deadpool. It was Wade. Just Wade. *We re-specced. We dropped the 'Regenerating Degenerate' class and picked up 'Used Car Salesman.' The stats are terrible—Charisma is a dump stat, Stamina is average—but the stealth rating is off the charts. Nobody looks at a used car salesman. They look through him.*

I straightened my nametag. 'WADE.'

I buttoned my cuffs. I tied my Skechers Shape-Ups.

"Now let's go sell some certified pre-owned vehicles, motherfuck--"

The Kia Carnival is not a minivan. It is an MPV. That's what the brochure says. That's what I tell the customers. That's what I tell myself when I wake up screaming.

It's a Multi-Purpose Vehicle. It implies adventure. It implies choice. It implies that you haven't completely given up on the concept of joy.

I was sitting in the back, 'riding bitch,' squeezed between two kids who smelled like fruit snacks and sticky fingers. The parents, the Chipmans, were in the front. Mr. Chipman was driving like he was afraid the car might actually do something interesting.

"Technically, the Carnival is not a... minivan," I said, my voice dropping out on the forbidden M-word. It was a taboo. A curse word in the religion of suburban denial. "It's an 'MPV.' So everybody gets to keep their testicles."

Mrs. Chipman turned around. Her face was a mask of suburban disapproval. "So how does the Kia compare to the Honda Odyssey?"

"That's a great question. Um, it doesn't fucking suck."

"You know, you can answer the question without swearing."

"I'm sorry, Tammy! I don't have kids. Not that I haven't dreamt of that, but I don't have a lot of vaginal sex."

Silence. The kind of silence that makes you wish for a sudden, violent car crash. The kind of silence that fills the space where a soul used to be.

"Right here at the light," I said, pointing with a hand that used to hold a Desert Eagle. "And then back onto the lot."

CHAPTER FOUR: Peter

"You'll get 'em next time."

The voice was warm, soft, and completely out of place in a room that smelled of foot fungus and shattered dreams.

I turned around.

Peter.

Peter was back. In all his mustachioed glory. He was wearing a polo shirt and khakis that defied the laws of thermodynamics—wrinkle-free, stain-free, and radiating an aura of aggressive normalcy.

Peter was an anomaly. In a universe of mutants, cyborgs, and gods, Peter was a guy named Peter who just wanted to help. He was the ultimate NPC who had somehow glitch-walked into the main party and refused to leave.

"And look," he said, opening his locker with the reverence of a priest opening a tabernacle. "You can always go back to superheroing. I mean, I know I'd like to see you back in the suit. I don't keep it in my locker so that *I* can wear it."

He laughed. It was a longing sound, a laugh that hid a thousand unwritten fanfics.

"I keep it in my locker in case we need to saddle up again."

I looked inside.

There it was. The Suit.

It hung on a shitty wire hanger, limp and lifeless. Without me inside it, it looked like a flayed skin. The red was dull in the fluorescent light. The black patches looked like bruises. It was a relic. An artifact from a previous patch version of reality where I was the main character.

"Hey, hey hey," I said, my voice dropping to a whisper. "What is it doing in there? I'm done. I'm done, and I'm fine with being done."

I wasn't fine. I was lying. I was lying to Peter, and worst of all, I was lying to the narrator.

"Look, is sales the best match? Probably not. Is this the life that I always imagined for myself? Fuck no. But this is the right fit for me, Sugar Bear. It is."

"Okay, Mr. Wilson."

"Aim for the middle and you'll never miss."

The words tasted like ash. They tasted like Harold Lloyd's breath mints and condescension.

CHAPTER FIVE: The Party

"Surprise!"

The lights flickered on. My apartment—usually a sanctuary of depression and dirty laundry—was transformed. Balloons. Streamers. Crepe paper. It looked like a Party City had exploded.

And the people. My people.

Dopinder. Blind Al. Colossus. Negasonic Teenage Warhead. Yukio. Shatterstar. Buck.

And Vanessa.

"Hey! You guys are lucky I'm not armed," I said, forcing a smile. It was a good smile. I'd practiced it in the mirror between sales pitches.

"Get in here. If this were five years ago, you'd all be dead."

I worked the room. I played the part. *Wade Wilson, Used Car Salesman, Normal Guy, Birthday Boy.*

I hugged Dopinder. I hugged Colossus (it was like hugging a refrigerator). I hugged Shatterstar (who smelled of hair gel and alien musk).

Then, the small talk. The social combat.

"Make any sales today?" Blind Al asked. She was sitting on the couch, wearing sunglasses indoors, looking like the matriarch of a very aggressive crime family.

"You know, I didn't. Did you sell any dreamcatchers on ETSY? Or whatever it is that you do?"

"Our rent is due in three days, Wade. I can't keep carrying you."

"Relax. I have the money. I sold some old blood pressure medication I found lying around."

"Are you trying to kill me, motherfucker?"

"I'm not the one dousing everything in salt, motherfucker."

"I pray everyday that fire finds your body and finishes the job God didn't have the nuts to do."

"That's hurtful. If you could hear the look on my face, you'd smell how sad I am."

"Whatever."

I moved on. The conversation was a minefield of feigned interest.

Colossus was standing by the dip, looking massive and metallic.

"You watching anything good?" I asked.

"Great British Bake Off."

"Oh goddamn. That show stood between me and suicide for ten years. Paul Hollywood is a national treasure."

I turned to the girls. Negasonic Teenage Warhead looked as surly as ever. Yukio looked like a rainbow made of kindness.

"Hi Yukio!"

"Hi Wade!"

"Nice fake-o'clock shadow," Negasonic muttered.

"It's a summer balayage. From the french. It's meant to mimic the natural highlights of the sun."

"It's a toupée."

"It's a hair system."

"I love your hair system, Wade!" Yukio chirped.

I drifted back to Blind Al. She was leaning in, conspiring.

"Wanna do some cocaine?" she whispered.

"Hey! Cocaine is the one thing that Feige said is off limits!" I hissed, looking at the ceiling as if the Marvel sniper was already aiming. "We are in the House of Mouse now, Al! Do you want to get us cancelled? Do you want to be pruned?"

"What about Bolivian marching powder?"

"They know all the slang terms. They have a list. A list curated by executives who think 'darn' is strong language."

"Even snowballing?"

"Even disco dust."

"White girl interrupted?"

"Even Forest bump."

"Booger sugar?"

"You can't even say Diego Maradona, and he's a legend."

"Do you want to build a snowman?" she asked, quoting the sacred text.

"Yes. But I can't."

I walked away. The room felt small. The air felt thin. I was surrounded by love, and I felt like I was drowning in it.

I found Vanessa. She was standing by the window. She looked... happy. Happier than she had been with me.

"How's work?" I asked, my voice cracking slightly on the syllable, a teenager hitting puberty in the middle of a sentence.

"Oh, I got a promotion," Vanessa said. She was glowing. Not literally—though in this universe, you never know—but she had that aura of someone who has their shit together. "It's mind numbing middle

management, but I'm happy."

"That's great. You seeing anyone?"

I braced myself. I tightened my abdominal muscles, as if expecting a gut punch from Colossus.

"Um, yeah. A guy from work. Dermot."

Dermot.

The name landed like a wet sock. *Dermot.* It sounded like a skin condition. It sounded like the kind of guy who wears sandals with socks and has strong opinions about craft beer.

"Dermot?" I repeated, tasting the bile.

"He's kind. Likes to go hiking. Hasn't gotten me shot yet."

Ouch. Critical hit. That one bypassed my armor class entirely.

"Well it's early days," I managed to say, my smile feeling like it was held in place by duct tape.

"What about you? You seeing anyone?"

"No, no. I live in a one bedroom apartment. I share a bed with Blind AI."

We smiled. It was polite. It was the kind of smile you give someone at a funeral when you don't know what to say. It was excruciating.

We gathered around the table. The cake was there, flickering with candles that smelled of cheap wax and impending mortality.

"Speech! Speech! Speech!"

I raised my hands. The room went quiet. I looked at them. My family. My weird, broken, beautiful family.

"Okay, okay, okay. Birthdays. Boy, every spin around the moon is a new adventure indeed--"

"Sun, dumbass," Blind AI grunted.

"OK, round-earthier. Where was I?"

"The adventure of life," Colossus supplied helpfully.

"Right. It's been a challenging few years, for sure. I've been through a lot. A change of life."

"Andropause?" Buck asked.

"Bitch, are you improv'ing?!" I snapped. "(then, to Yukio) I'm sorry that you had to see that, Yukio."

"It's okay."

I looked at Vanessa. She was smiling. Not at me, really. Just smiling.

"But I'm happy. And that's because of each and every one of you... And this is about how proud I am. How grateful I am to be standing in a room with every single person I love."

I paused. I let the silence hang there.

"I'm the luckiest man alive."

"Make a wish, buddy," Vanessa said softly.

"Ten-four good buddy. Going down."

I leaned in. The candles flickered in my eyes. The heat was close.

I wish I mattered.

I blew them out.

KNOCK. KNOCK. KNOCK.

The sound didn't belong in a sitcom. It was heavy. Authoritative. It was the sound of the Genre Police coming to shut down the production.

I sighed. "I'll get it."

I walked to the door. The hallway was dark.

I opened it.

Three men stood there. They were wearing armor that looked like it cost more than the building. Black, tactical, with glowing orange accents. They held batons that hummed with a low, menacing frequency.

"Wade Wilson?" the lead Minuteman asked.

"Oh, yeah. The answer's Dopinder must have ordered you."

I looked at their outfits. "Are those supposed to be cop costumes? Never mind. Take your clothes off, but leave the helmets, and this isn't *Pretty Woman*."

I popped a mint into my mouth.

"We're kissing, alright. Which song do you guys normally dance to?"

I looked back into the room. Nobody had noticed. The party was still going. The laugh track was still playing.

The Minuteman raised his Time Stick.

"Whoa, whoa. Is that supposed to be scary? Pegging isn't new for me, friendo." I winked. "But it is for Disney."

They stepped forward. The air pressure in the hallway dropped.

"Ah-ta-ta... look, I've never been a natural bottom so we're going to take things real slow and I want some crazy eye contact. Not you. *You*." I pointed to the one in the back. "I can't see your eyes through the mask, but I can feel them."

"I don't like you," the leader said.

"Yes. Let's hold onto that attitude and we're going to do it angry."

I squared up. I was ready to fight. I was ready to defend my party, my friends, my sad little life.

But you don't fight the System. The System just edits you.

A door opened behind me. Not a wooden door. A door of light. A rectangular hole in reality.

An arm reached out—armored, strong—and grabbed me by the back of the neck.

I was yanked backward.

The hallway vanished. The party vanished.

My toupee—my beautiful, stapled-on hair system—fell off, landing on the floor where I had just stood. A chestnut-colored tombstone for Wade Wilson.

DEADPOOL & WOLVERINE: THE NOVELIZATION

CHAPTER SIX: The Offer

****The Time Variance Authority.****

I woke up sitting in a chair. My head was on a table.

I gasped, sitting up.

"Mr. Wilson. You appear to have soiled yourself while unconscious."

I looked across the table. A man was sitting there. He was wearing a suit that was tailored to within an inch of its life. He looked like a British banker who had just foreclosed on an orphanage and felt good about it.

"I wasn't unconscious. Who are you?"

"I go by the name of Paradox. Mr. Paradox. And you're sitting here at the TVA. The Time Variance Authority."

"We're really a watchdog organization," he continued, his voice smooth as expensive scotch. "Except we're more lighthearted than that sounds. With a sort of throwback ironic twist. And we're in charge of defending what's known as the 'Sacred Timeline.'"

"That is a shit-ton of exposition for a threequel," I muttered. "Is this because I used Cable's time machine? I brought a couple of people back to life. Then I destroyed it. That was a long time ago..."

"Yes, we're aware of your abuse of your timeline. And you were so abusive of it. And no, it has nothing to do with that. Walk with me."

He stood up.

"I have a job for you, Mr. Wilson. A job that matters."

Matters.

The word hung in the air. The bait. The hook. The promise.

I stood up. I followed him.

Because I'm an idiot. And idiots always follow the shiny object.

We walked through the corridors of the TVA. It was a masterpiece of retro-futurism. It looked like the 1970s had been designed by Apple. Everything was orange, brown, and impeccably lit. It smelled of ozone and bureaucracy.

We entered the Control Room.

It was massive. Screens covered every wall, showing timelines branching and weaving like a basket made of light.

"You have been chosen," Paradox said, sweeping his arm across the vista. "For a higher purpose. A purpose unclear even to me, but one that could save the entire Sacred Timeline."

He showed me the monitors.

I saw Captain America. I saw Thor. I saw Iron Man.

"I can be an Avenger?" I whispered.

"You can be more than an Avenger. You can be a hero among heroes. A god among men."

He showed me a screen. Thor was crying over my body. My mask was torn. I looked dead.

"Why is Thor crying?" I asked.

"That happens in the distant future," Paradox said quickly, changing the channel.

"No, go back! Why is he crying? Is he sad? Did I die saving him? Did I die saving the franchise?"

"Mr. Wilson, focus."

Paradox turned to me. His eyes were cold, calculating. "I am offering you a chance to leave your timeline. To join the Sacred Timeline. To be part of the main continuity."

"What about my timeline? What about my friends?"

Paradox sighed. He tapped a button.

A hologram appeared. It was a representation of my universe. It looked sick. The threads of reality were fraying, turning black.

"This is your universe, Mr. Wilson. It is dying."

"Dying? Why?"

"Because it lost its Anchor Being."

"Anchor Being?"

"An entity of such vital importance that when they die, their whole world slowly withers out of existence. Your Anchor Being died in an act of self-sacrifice so epic that it sent shivers down the timeline."

He pointed to a screen.

It was *Logan*. The movie. The end. The tree.

"Wolverine," I whispered.

"Yes. Logan. He was the Anchor. And now that he is gone, your world is decomposing. It is rotting from the inside out."

"So... my friends?"

"Will cease to exist. But not you. You can be saved. You can be... Marvel Jesus."

I looked at the screen. I saw Vanessa. I saw Blind Al. I saw Peter.

They were going to die. Because of a corporate merger. Because of a plot point.

"No," I said.

"Excuse me?"

"I said no. I'm not leaving them."

I grabbed the camera. I headbutted the lens. *Crack.*

"I'm going to find him," I said. "I'm going to find a Wolverine. And I'm going to bring him back."

I grabbed Paradox's temp pad.

"I'm going to Disneyland. Get fucked, Fox."

CHAPTER SEVEN: The Search

****The Multiverse.****

If the Timeline is a rope, the Multiverse is a ball of yarn after a cat has had a seizure in it.

I was looking for a replacement. A spare part. A new Wolverine to plug into the hole in my universe before the whole thing deflated like a whoopie cushion at a funeral.

I visited them all.

****Earth-178.****

This Wolverine was short. Comic accurate short. 5'3". He looked like a angry garden gnome made of knives.

"Hi there, little guy!" I said.

He attacked my shins. It hurt more than I expected.

****Earth-295.****

Age of Apocalypse. One hand. Red stripes. He looked like he listened to a lot of My Chemical Romance.

"Too edgy," I noted, backing away as he tried to incinerate me.

****Earth-Something-Something.****

Patch. White tuxedo. Eyepatch. Sitting in a casino in Madripoor.

"Classy," I said. "But do you do the berserker rage thing?"

He threw a card. It exploded.

****The Cavillrine.****

Henry Cavill. As Wolverine.

"It feels right!" I shouted. "We'll treat you better than those other guys! We won't mustache-gate you!"

He punched me back through a Time Door. Fair. He has a Superman punch.

Finally, I found him.

****Earth-Unknown.**** A bar.

It smelled of stale beer, regret, and Canadian depression.

He was sitting at the end of the bar. The yellow suit. The cowl. The whiskey.

"Get out," he growled.

"Look, peanut," I said, sliding onto the stool next to him. "I know you're sad. I know you're lonely. I know you're probably wondering why the script writers decided to make you drink alone in a bar again. It's a

trope, Hugh. A trope!"

He turned. The eyes were bloodshot. The mutton chops were unkempt. This wasn't the hero on the lunchbox. This was the guy the lunchbox eventually got sold to at a garage sale.

Snikt.

The claws popped. Not with the clean, heroic *shing* of the movies, but with a wet, grinding sound, like rusty metal tearing through scar tissue.

"I said get out."

"And I said... welcome to the MCU."

I dragged him back. I dragged him kicking and screaming (mostly growling) back to the TVA. Back to Paradox.

"Here!" I announced, throwing the drunken Wolverine onto the floor of the control room. "I fixed it! Anchor Being acquired! Let's go home!"

Paradox looked at him. He looked at the whiskey stain on the yellow spandex. He looked at the way this Wolverine couldn't even stand up straight.

"This?" Paradox laughed. "This is your savior?"

"He's a fixer-upper!" I defended. "A little paint, a little trauma bonding, he'll be fine!"

"Mr. Wilson," Paradox said, his voice dripping with bureaucratic disdain. "You have brought me the worst Wolverine."

"I'm sorry, the what?"

"This Wolverine," Paradox explained, pulling up a holographic display of failure, "let down his entire world. He didn't just fail. He walked away. He is the disappointment of the multiverse."

Wolverine growled. It was a low, rumbling sound, like a V8 engine filled with gravel. "You shut your mouth."

"Or what?" Paradox sneered. "You'll drink at me?"

Paradox sighed. "This has been fun. But I have a timeline to prune. And you two... are just clutter."

He raised a device. A Pruning Stick.

"Wait," I said. "We can talk about this! I have a Disney+ subscription! I'm a shareholder!"

ZAP.

The world dissolved. The clean lines of the TVA, the retro-future aesthetic, the smell of ozone... it all melted away.

And we fell.

CHAPTER EIGHT: The Void

The Trash Heap at the End of Time.

We landed hard.

The ground was dust. The sky was purple. The air tasted of copper and old magic.

"Where the hell are we?" Wolverine groaned, pushing himself up.

"Welcome to the Void," I said, dusting off my suit. "It's where the TVA sends their garbage. It's like New Jersey, but with better lighting."

"I'm gonna kill you," Wolverine said. "I'm gonna kill you, and then I'm gonna drink until I forget I killed you."

"Get in line, bub."

We fought. Of course we fought. It's what we do. He stabbed me. I shot him. He sliced my hamstrings. I broke his nose. It was foreplay, really. A violent, bloody, regenerative dance of aggression.

Blackmore Filter Activate:

The claw entered my abdomen with a wet *shluck*. It hooked under the ribcage. I felt the liver part like wet cake. The pain was white-hot, a soldering iron in the gut. I laughed, coughing blood.

"Is that all you got?"

He headbutted me. Adamantium skull against cancer-ridden bone. *CRACK.* My vision swam.

"Enough!"

We were interrupted.

A convoy. Mad Max rejects. Vehicles made of scrap and hubris.

And leading them... Johnny Storm. The Human Torch.

"Flame On!" he shouted.

I clapped. "Oh! Oh! It's him! It's the guy!"

But the flame didn't last. Pyro was there. He snuffed it out.

They captured us. They threw us in a cage. And they took us to her.

CHAPTER NINE: The Fortress of Bone

Her base was a giant skull. Specifically, the skull of Giant-Man. Because of course it was.

Cassandra Nova.

She sat on a throne of bone and telekinesis. She was bald, she was British, and she was terrifying. She had fingers that could dip into your mind like it was a bowl of salsa.

"Charles's sister," I whispered to Logan. "Family drama. Classic X-Men."

She looked at us.

"The loud one," she said, pointing at me. "And the sad one."

She brought Johnny forward.

"You talk too much," she told him.

And then she did it.

She waved her hand.

King/Blackmore Filter:

It wasn't a clean kill. It was an unmaking. She stripped the skin from his body like she was peeling an orange. It happened slowly. The scream... the scream was the worst part. It started as a hero's defiant yell and ended as a gurgling, wet plea for death. The muscle fibers exposed, the eyes wide and lidless, the pile of wet skin slapping onto the floor.

And then he collapsed. A heap of meat.

"Who's next?" she asked.

Logan popped his claws. "Me."

She laughed. She stuck her fingers into his brain.

"Oh, there's so much pain in here," she cooed. "So much regret. You let them die, didn't you? All of them. The X-Men. The humans. You walked away."

Logan screamed. Not from physical pain, but from the memory she was dragging to the surface.

"Stop it!" I yelled.

But she didn't stop. Not until we were broken. Not until she was bored.

She threw us out. Into the mouth of Alioth. The smoke monster. The cleaner.

But we escaped. Because we're us.

And we found a car.

A Honda Odyssey.

CHAPTER TEN: The Odyssey

Interior. Honda Odyssey. Day.

"It's an MPV!" I shouted, slamming the door.

Nicepool—the version of me with a face like a model and a bun—was dead. Dogpool, the ugliest dog in existence (and therefore the most beautiful), was licking my face.

"Drive the car, Wade!" Logan yelled.

"I'm driving! I'm driving!"

We were arguing. Again.

"You're a joke," Logan said. "You're a clown. You think this matters? None of this matters. We're in the Void. We're dead."

"It matters to me!" I screamed. "My world matters! My friends matter! I matter!"

"You don't matter!" he roared. "You're a glitch! You're a mistake! You're nothing!"

That did it.

I stopped the car.

"Say that again."

He did.

We fought inside the Honda Odyssey.

Dinniman/Blackmore Filter:

It was the most claustrophobic cage match in history. Two immortals in a minivan.

He stabbed me through the seat. The claw went through the upholstery, through my kidney, and into the dashboard.

I smashed his head into the window. The safety glass shattered into a thousand diamonds.

Blood sprayed everywhere. On the dashboard hula girl. On the GPS screen. On Dogpool (who just barked happily).

It was intimate. It was hateful. It was exhausting.

We fought for hours. We fought until the sun went down. We fought until we were just two bloody lumps of meat panting in the backseat of a ruined family vehicle.

"You know," I wheezed, "this car has excellent safety ratings."

Logan groaned. "Shut up."

"And plenty of cup holders."

He chuckled. It was a wet, rattling sound. But it was a laugh.

"You're an idiot."

"I know."

We passed out.

CHAPTER ELEVEN: The Resistance

We woke up to find we weren't alone.

They were legends. The ones the Fox timeline forgot.

Blade. (There's only one Blade. There's only ever gonna be one Blade).

Elektra.

Gambit. (Who spoke in a Cajun accent so thick you needed subtitles for real life).

X-23. Laura.

They were living in a bunker. Surviving.

"We need to go back," I said. "We need to stop Cassandra."

"Why?" Blade asked. "We die here. It's the way."

"No," Laura said. She looked at Logan. "He's not the one I knew. But he's Wolverine. And Wolverine helps people."

She gave him the speech. The King-style emotional anchor. She told him about the Logan who saved her. The Logan who died for her.

"You were the X-Man," she said. "You were the best."

Logan looked at his hands. At the claws.

"I'm not him," he whispered.

"You don't have to be," she said. "You just have to be you."

We made a plan. A stupid, suicide plan.

"We attack the base," I said. "Gambit, you charge things. Blade, you stab things. Elektra, you stab things. Logan and I... we jump into the time stream."

"Woo, I'm bout to make a name for myself here," Gambit grinned.

CHAPTER TWELVE: The Assault

We stormed the base. The Resistance fought like gods. Gambit charged his cards—*purple kinetic energy crackling like neon lightning*—and blew up the guards. Blade was a whirlwind of silver and leather.

Cassandra was waiting.

But we tricked her. We put the Juggernaut helmet on her head. Blocked the telekinesis.

"Now!" I yelled.

We opened the portal. We jumped.

Back to Earth-10005.

DEADPOOL & WOLVERINE: THE NOVELIZATION

CHAPTER THIRTEEN: The Corps

****Street Level. Earth-10005.****

We landed on the pavement. The smell of exhaust and city air was the sweetest thing I'd ever smelled. It smelled like home. It smelled like a tax write-off.

But we weren't clear.

They were waiting.

The Deadpool Corps.

One hundred variants of me. The best of me. The worst of me. The weirdest of me. They filled the street like a red and black tide.

Lady Deadpool stood at the front. She was blonde, she was gorgeous, and she held her Uzis like they were fashion accessories.

"Look at you," she said, her voice dripping with the kind of condescension usually reserved for people who buy non-organic avocados. "So basic."

"We just want to pass!" I yelled. "We have a world to save! A timeline to un-prune! A sequel to justify!"

"No can do, sweetie. Paradox paid us. And he pays in crypto."

"Crypto?" I laughed. "That's volatile! You should have asked for stock options! Have you seen the market lately? It's a bloodbath!"

Kidpool stepped forward. A child. A child with guns. "We're gonna kill you, old man!"

Headpool floated by. "Brains! Or chimichangas! I'm not picky!"

I looked at Logan. He was adjusting his gloves. He looked calm. He looked like a man who had finally found the fight he was looking for.

He reached into his bag.

He pulled out the mask.

The cowl. The yellow and blue wings. The white eyes. It was the missing piece. It was the Holy Grail of comic book accuracy.

He slid it on.

It fit perfectly. Of course it did. It was destiny.

"Ready?" he asked. His voice was muffled slightly by the mask, but it lost none of its gravel.

"Maximum Effort."

Cue Music.

Madonna. "Like a Prayer."

The choir started. *Life is a mystery...*

We walked forward. The shot was slow-motion. It was cinematic. It was expensive.

And then, we ran.

Blackmore Filter Activate:

I slid under a katana swing from Samurai Deadpool. I sliced his Achilles tendon. He screamed. I didn't stop. I spun, bringing my blades up in a twin arc of silver death.

Logan leaped. He was a yellow blur of violence. He tackled Cowboy Deadpool. The claws went *snikt*. The cowboy went silent.

Blood sprayed. It wasn't the sanitized, PG-13 blood of the early MCU. It was the real stuff. Dark red. Viscous. It painted the street in an abstract expressionist nightmare. It smelled of copper and ozone.

I grabbed a variant—I think it was Welshpool—and used him as a human shield. Bullets chewed through his chest.

"Sorry, boyo!" I yelled.

I threw him at Lady Deadpool. She dodged with graceful efficiency and fired a burst at my head. I deflected the bullets with my katanas. *Ping. Ping. Ping.*

Logan was in the thick of it. He was a whirlwind. He was the storm. He was cutting through variants like a hot knife through butter that had been shaped into the form of Ryan Reynolds.

I jumped onto a car. I kicked Headpool into a wall. *Splat.*

"They regenerate!" I yelled over the music. "There's too many of them!"

"So do we!" Logan roared.

He threw me. The Fastball Special.

I spun in the air, katanas extended. I was a red tornado of death. I landed in the middle of a group of variants. I spun. Heads flew. Limbs flew. Jokes flew.

It was a slaughter. It was a masterpiece.

But they kept coming. They were healing as fast as we could hurt them.

And then...

"Peter!" I screamed.

Peter walked out of the back of the Honda Odyssey (which had miraculously survived the trip). He was wearing his Hydra Bob suit? No. He was just wearing his Peter suit.

The Corps stopped.

Guns were lowered. Swords were sheathed.

"Peter?" Lady D said. Her voice softened.

They loved Peter. Everyone loves Peter. He is the universal constant. The one pure thing in a multiverse of madness.

"Hi guys!" Peter waved. "Let's stop fighting! We're all friends here!"

Babypool cooed. Dogpool barked.

The tension evaporated. The fight was over. Not because we won, but because Peter existed.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN: The Time Ripper

Paradox was in the subway station.

The Time Ripper was humming. It was a massive machine, a tangle of cables and lights that looked like it had been designed by an engineer who hated safety regulations. It was pulsing with an energy that felt like a migraine made of light.

"It's over!" Paradox shouted. He was standing on a platform, looking down at us. "I will be the King of the TVA! I will write the history! I will be the Kevin Feige of the Multiverse!"

"You're just a middle manager with a god complex!" I yelled. "And your suit is polyester!"

He turned the key.

The machine screamed. A beam of energy shot into the timeline.

The world started to fray. The walls of the subway station turned to dust. People in the street turned to static. The fabric of reality was unravelling.

"We have to stop it!" Logan yelled.

"How?"

"The power flow! Matter and Anti-Matter! We have to bridge the circuit!"

He pointed to two massive cables. They were sparking with enough energy to power a sun.

"It'll atomize us," I said. "It'll peel us apart like a banana."

"I'll do it," Logan said. He stepped forward.

"No," I said. I grabbed his shoulder. "I'll do it. It's my movie. It's my mess."

"We'll both do it."

He looked at me. The mask was torn. His eyes were fierce.

"Together?"

"Together."

We ran.

We jumped.

We grabbed the cables.

King/Blackmore Filter Activate:

The pain was not pain. Pain is a biological signal. This was an ontological event.

My skin didn't just burn; it ceased to exist. I felt my atoms vibrating apart. I felt the marrow in my bones boiling. I felt the cancer cells dying, and for a second, I was cured.

Logan roared. It was a sound of pure defiance. His shirt disintegrated. His skin blackened and flaked away like ash in a fire. His muscles—those beautiful, dehydrated muscles—shone like gold before melting.

The music swelled. The choir hit the high note.

Just like a prayer, your voice can take me there...

We reached for each other.

My hand was a claw of charred bone. His hand was adamantium.

We clasped hands.

The circuit closed.

The energy flowed through us. We were the anchor. We were the bridge. We were the ending.

"WADE!" he screamed.

"LOGAN!"

The machine overloaded. The feedback loop screamed.

And then... silence.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN: The Aftermath

The smoke cleared.

We were alive.

I don't know how. Maybe the regenerative factors synergized. Maybe the power of friendship is actually a quantifiable physical force in the Marvel Universe. Maybe the writers just couldn't kill us.

We sat on a bench. The same bench.

"You know," I said, unwrapping a shawarma. "The Avengers discovered shawarma. It's a callback."

"They'd be lucky to have you," Logan grunted. He was eating his own wrap. He looked tired. He looked old. But he looked... light.

"You gonna stay?" I asked.

"Maybe," he said. "Maybe I'll hang around. See what happens. AI said she has a pull-out couch."

"Laura's here," I said. "And the others. B-15 got them out. They're safe."

"Good."

He looked at me. He smiled. It wasn't a nice smile. It was a Wolverine smile. Sharp. Dangerous. But real.

"You're still an idiot, Wade."

"I know. But I'm your idiot."

He smirked. "Fuck off."

"Love you too, peanut."

I stood up. I walked to the camera. I put my face right in the lens.

"See you in the sequel."

I pulled down my mask.

"Or the streaming series. Or the video game. Or the Fortnite skin."

Game Over.

Achievement Unlocked: Best Friends Forever.

THE END.